

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

The post-Gupta period, which spanned from circa sixth to the twelfth century a period of six centuries, is denoted as early medieval period in the realm of Indian history, marking a transition to medieval times. Early medieval is used as an historical phase and marked off from other historical phases such as ancient, medieval, and modern. However, the notion of these phases being rigidly defined and differentiated is a relatively recent development. What is more recent is the critical examination of using these terms as mere substitute for hindu, muslim and british periods.¹

The term "early medieval" depicts both a specific chronological period and a set of transformative processes that define this phase. To understand this phase, it is essential to reassess current historical perspectives on the early medieval period and how the transition to this phase has been interpreted. By framing the early medieval period as a transitional phase to the medieval era, we adopt a particular narrative about the progression of Indian history.² Serious efforts to define this period began in the late 1950s. Marxist historians attributed the emergence of multiple regional powers and the absence of a unified pan-Indian authority to the concept of "Indian feudalism." This perspective highlighted the interconnections between economy, society, and polity, distinguishing early Indian history from the early medieval period and characterizing the latter as feudal in nature. The nomenclature ascribed to early medieval period has neither been accepted nor denied by several historians in fact it has been debated for a long time and now is a valid chronological segment of historical enquires.³ It was sometimes called the 'dark age' or the period of crisis by various eminent scholars. The dark age was first coined by Petrarch, an Italian scholar, in the 1330's to describe the post-Roman centuries.⁴ Though the period of early medieval gave rise to the concept of feudalism in Indian history.

Feudalism is complex and defies a rigid definition. However, its universal characteristics, as noted by historians like Marc Bloch and E.A. Kosminsky, include a predominantly agrarian economy with a class division between landlords and subjugated peasants. In this system, landlords extract surplus produce from peasants using extra-

economic means, such as social, religious, or political coercion, rather than purely economic mechanisms.⁵ Thus, it refers to a system where the means of production are controlled and distributed in a specific way, and surplus value is extracted and appropriated by a particular class or group, often through hierarchical relationships and obligations.⁶ The term feudalism is said to be used by the Bhupendranath Datta in 1944 in his work titled 'Studies in Indian Social Polity'.⁷ B.N. Datta referred to P.N Banerjee who claims that the institution of feudalism took its rise in India, but no one is certain when did it really began.⁸ The changes did not emerge abruptly but rather evolved over time, with noticeable shifts beginning to take shape around CE 550-650 across various regions of the subcontinent. According to historians like Romila Thapar, the preceding centuries (CE 300-600) can be seen as a threshold times, marked by the incipient forms of these changes.⁹ As these developments matured, distinct features in socio-economic, cultural, and political life became more pronounced during the subsequent period, leading many historians to categorize CE 600-1200 as the early medieval phase in Indian history. This phase is notable for the consolidation of new patterns and structures that defined the era.

The early medieval period in Indian history has been subject to diverse interpretations among scholars, leading to enriching debates and a deeper understanding of the times. Despite these differences, historians across various schools of thought converge on certain key aspects. Notably, there is a broad consensus that the early medieval situation in India cannot be adequately grasped by merely focusing on dynastic shifts and changes in ruling powers. Instead, historians emphasize the need for a more comprehensive approach that integrates political developments with socio-economic and cultural dimensions, including the role of belief systems.¹⁰ By adopting this holistic perspective, scholars aim to capture the complexities and distinctive features of the period. Our work studies the principles, providing a detailed examination of the early medieval scenario over a span of six centuries, beginning from CE 600, and exploring the interconnected facets of Indian education and its development during this time.

D.D. Kosambi and R.S. Sharma pioneered the field, applying Marxist and feudalism frameworks to analyze socio-economic structures. Later, scholars such as D.C. Sircar, B.N.S. Yadava and Harbans Mukhia expanded on these ideas, exploring state formation, societal dynamics, and regional variations. More recent contributions from

Burton Stein, D.N. Jha, B.D. Chattopadhyaya, Ranbir Chakravarti and Irfan Habib, have further nuanced our understanding, introducing concepts like segmentary state and critiquing earlier frameworks. This evolution reflects the complexity and richness of early medieval India, highlighting the need for multifaceted approaches to grasp its history. The concept of feudalism was first applied to the Indian context by James Todd, a historian who studied history of Rajasthan in the early 19th century. Todd was influenced by European historical perspectives of the empirical writings of Henri Pirenne and Marc Bloch. Todd saw similarities between the lord-vassal relationships in European feudalism and the power structures in Rajasthan.¹¹ He essentially transplanted the European concept of feudalism onto the Indian context, highlighting the relationships between local rulers, nobles, and their subjects. This marks an early attempt to understand Indian history through the lens of feudalism, a concept that was later debated and refined by other historians.

D.D. Kosambi¹² significantly contributed to understanding feudalism in Indian socio-economic history.¹³ He conceptualized the growth of feudalism in India as a dual process, where it developed "from above" through royal land grants to officials and Brāhmans, particularly during the Gupta and post Gupta periods and "from below" as individuals and small groups from village levels rose to power, becoming landlords and vassals.¹⁴ This two stage development theory, however, was later subject to criticism from various scholars, sparking debates on the nature and complexities of feudalism in Indian history.¹⁵ Kosambi's work remains pivotal in highlighting the intricate dynamics of feudalism, inviting further analysis and discussion.¹⁶

R.S. Sharma's¹⁷ perspective on Indian feudalism emphasizes the pivotal role of land grants to Brahmins, temples, and monasteries, which can be traced back to the Sātavāhana period and became more widespread during the Gupta period, as evidenced by numerous copper plate inscriptions. According to Sharma, the core economic characteristic of Indian feudalism was the emergence of intermediaries who controlled land, leading to the subjugation and enslavement of peasants.¹⁸ This enslavement manifested through several mechanisms:

1. Restrictions on Mobility: Peasants freedom was curtailed, limiting their ability to move or change their occupation.

2. Forced Labor (*Viśhtī*): The obligation to perform unpaid labor increased, further burdening the peasantry.
3. Mounting Tax Burdens: The imposition of heavy taxes added to the economic strain on peasants.
4. Subinfeudation: A system where intermediaries further delegated land control to others, creating multiple layers of feudal obligations and exploitation.¹⁹

Sharma identifies the Gupta and post-Gupta periods as crucial for the development of feudalism, marked by specific features such as: Land Grants: Both virgin and cultivable lands were granted to beneficiaries, altering land ownership and control patterns.²⁰ Transfer of Peasants along with land grants, peasants were often transferred, highlighting their subjugated status. The practice of forced labor became more widespread, contributing to the decline in peasants rights and living conditions.²¹ Restrictions on Movement not just peasants, but artisans and merchants also faced restrictions on their movements, reflecting a broader control over the population.²²

Sharma also highlights the decline of long-distance trade with various parts of the world following the decline of the Gupta empire. This decline in trade had significant consequences as urban decline, Cities suffered, leading to a deurbanization. The ruralization of the economy further entrenched feudal structures.²³

Sharma's analysis paints a picture of a feudal system in India characterized by the exploitation of the peasantry, decline of trade and urban centers, and the strengthening of landed intermediaries, all contributing to a feudal order that shaped the socio-economic landscape of early medieval India. The complexities of rural life and inter-village cooperation in ancient India have been underscored, leading to discussions around the theory of the Kaliyuga crisis.²⁴ This concept has been explored by B.N.S. Yadava and R.S. Sharma, who linked it to significant social transitions in medieval India.²⁵ According to B.N.S. Yadava, the Kaliyuga concept was tied to the medieval social shift, particularly highlighting the impact of the Huna invasions that weakened the Gupta empire and facilitated the rise of feudalism. R.S. Sharma first introduced the idea of the Kali crisis in 1958 in his seminal publication *Sudras in Ancient India*. He elaborated on this concept in 1982 article and refined his arguments in 2001.²⁶ Sharma's exploration of

the Kali crisis suggests that it was not a historical crisis in the conventional sense but rather a reflection of the Brahmanas concerns about their status and patronage.²⁷ This perceived crisis may have stemmed from the competition Brahmanas faced from the heretical sects, which challenged their traditional dominance and authority.²⁸

Moreover, Sharma posits that the Kali crisis could be seen as an article of confidence among Brahmanas, reflecting their anxieties about maintaining their social and religious influence in a changing environment.²⁹ This period was marked by economic growth, social change, and the expansion of state societies beyond the Gangetic north India, all within the Brahmanical framework. The Kali crisis, therefore, might be interpreted as a strategic narrative crafted by Brahmanas to enforce conformity to Brahmanical norms and values among the populace.³⁰

In essence, the theory of the Kali crisis, as developed by Sharma and considered by other historians like Yadava, highlights the ideological and social tensions of the time.³¹ It underscores the efforts of the Brahmanas to maintain their authority and influence in the face of changing socio-economic conditions and religious competition.³² Rather than an actual historical crisis, the Kali crisis represents a complex interplay of social, economic, and ideological factors that shaped the discourse of the time. This perspective offers valuable insights into the dynamics of ancient Indian society, particularly the ways in which religious and social elites responded to challenges and changes in their environment.³³

The feudal interpretation of Indian history, which emphasizes land grants as a key factor, has been subject to criticism. Some historians argue that transferring revenue to beneficiaries (donees) may not necessarily erode the economic authority of the ruler. D.C. Sircar criticizes Marxist historians for blurring the lines between landlordism, tenancy, and feudalism in the Indian context.³⁴ Instead, Sircar prefers to use the concept of landlordism to describe the early medieval Indian situation, suggesting that it more accurately captures the dynamics of the time.³⁵

Harbans Mukhia³⁶ challenged the Indian feudalism thesis in his address "Was There Feudalism in Indian History?" questioning it on both theoretical and empirical grounds.³⁷ By comparing early medieval India with early medieval Europe, Mukhia

highlighted key differences. Unlike European feudalism, which emerged from societal changes, Indian feudalism was attributed to state actions, prompting Mukhia to doubt whether complex social structures can be imposed through administrative measures. Mukhia characterized the medieval Indian economy as having:

1. High land fertility: Favoring agricultural productivity.
2. Low peasant subsistence needs: Suggesting relative economic stability.
3. Peasant control over production: Emphasizing peasants' autonomy.³⁸

Mukhia emphasized free peasant production as a defining feature of medieval India's economy. He advocated for moving beyond Eurocentric perspectives in historical studies, broadening the debate beyond feudalism and trade. This intervention expanded the discourse, encouraging a more nuanced understanding of Indian history.³⁹

The points raised by Harbans Mukhia invites serious attention of scholars. The debate on Indian feudalism led historians to critically examine the universality of the concept, with each taking an independent stance. R.S. Sharma, while defending his thesis, refined it in his paper "How Feudal was Indian Feudalism?" Sharma suggested that feudalism is best understood as a mode of distributing means of production and appropriating surplus. He characterized feudalism as emerging in predominantly agrarian economies marked by a class division between landlords and servile peasantry, where landlords extract surplus through extra-economic methods, including social, religious, or political coercion. This nuanced perspective underscored the complex power dynamics and economic relationships in early medieval India.⁴⁰

D.N. Jha,⁴¹ while supporting the Indian feudalism theory, criticized R.S. Sharma's emphasis on the decline of long-distance trade as a primary factor in the rise of feudalism. In his work *The Feudal Order*, Jha explored the cultural and ideological dimensions of feudal society, focusing on the role of the Bhakti movement in North and South India and the growth of regional cultures and languages.⁴² This work highlighted the complex social and cultural aspects of feudalism in India, moving beyond purely economic explanations.⁴³

The Segmentary state model, originally developed by Aidan Southall for the Alur society in East Africa, was adopted by Burton Stein to explain the polity of south Indian

states from the Pallava to the Vijayanagara period.⁴⁴ Stein argued that this model better captures the complexities of South Indian politics than the feudal model, suggesting that kings had limited territorial sovereignty with central authority confined to core areas and quasi-autonomous administrative centers elsewhere.⁴⁵ According to Stein, real power resided in locality-level centers or *Nādūs*, and he distinguished between ritual sovereignty, which represented the king's symbolic authority, and actual political control, which was exercised at the local level, highlighting the nuanced dynamics of power in medieval South India.⁴⁶

Hermann Kulke⁴⁷ criticized Burton Stein's concept of ritual sovereignty, arguing that in traditional Indian society, ritual authority is often integral to and even precedes political power. Kulke also questioned the applicability of segmentary state model to stratified societies like early medieval India, particularly the idea of a Brahman-peasant alliance in the *Nādū*, which implies exploitation by the Brahman and Kshatriya classes. Instead Kulke, along with other non-aligned historians, proposes the concept of an integrative polity to understand early medieval Indian politics, suggesting a more complex and cohesive system of governance.⁴⁸

The integrative paradigm, which emerged as an alternative in the mid-1990s, particularly with B.D. Chattopadhyaya's *The Making of Early Medieval India*, offers a new perspective on state formation. The concept of Indian feudalism according to Chattopadhyaya has become so widely accepted as an explanatory model that the debate has shifted from questioning its existence to exploring the specific mechanisms and details of its development in India.⁴⁹ Chattopadhyaya distinguishes between parcelized and shared sovereignty, suggesting that power shifts between centers and peripheries rather than states collapsing.⁵⁰ Chattopadhyaya posited that the analysis he provided for the early medieval period is the polar opposite to the attributes of early historical society. Chattopadhyaya talks about political decentralization to be a new understanding of a structure characterized by decentralization and hierarchy.⁵¹ This perspective posits a state structure that contrasts with the centralized, bureaucratic state, which crystallized only in the post-Gupta period.⁵² The emergence of landed intermediaries a dominant landholding social group, is considered a hallmark of Indian feudal social formation. This development is linked to the disintegration and

decentralization of state authority and significant changes in agrarian relations.⁵³ The practice of land grants, primarily to *brāhmaṇas* or religious establishments in the early centuries CE, is seen as a causal factor.⁵⁴ The transition to early medieval society was marked by a shift from a market or money economy to self-sufficient villages as production units, leading to ruralization eventually reviving features of the early historical economy, such as trade, urbanism, and a market economy.⁵⁵ The post Gupta period saw a significant proliferation of castes, marking a key dimension of social stratification.⁵⁶ The ideology of the period was characterized by *bhakti*, which was feudal in nature, emphasizing loyalty and devotion reminiscent of feudal ties.⁵⁷

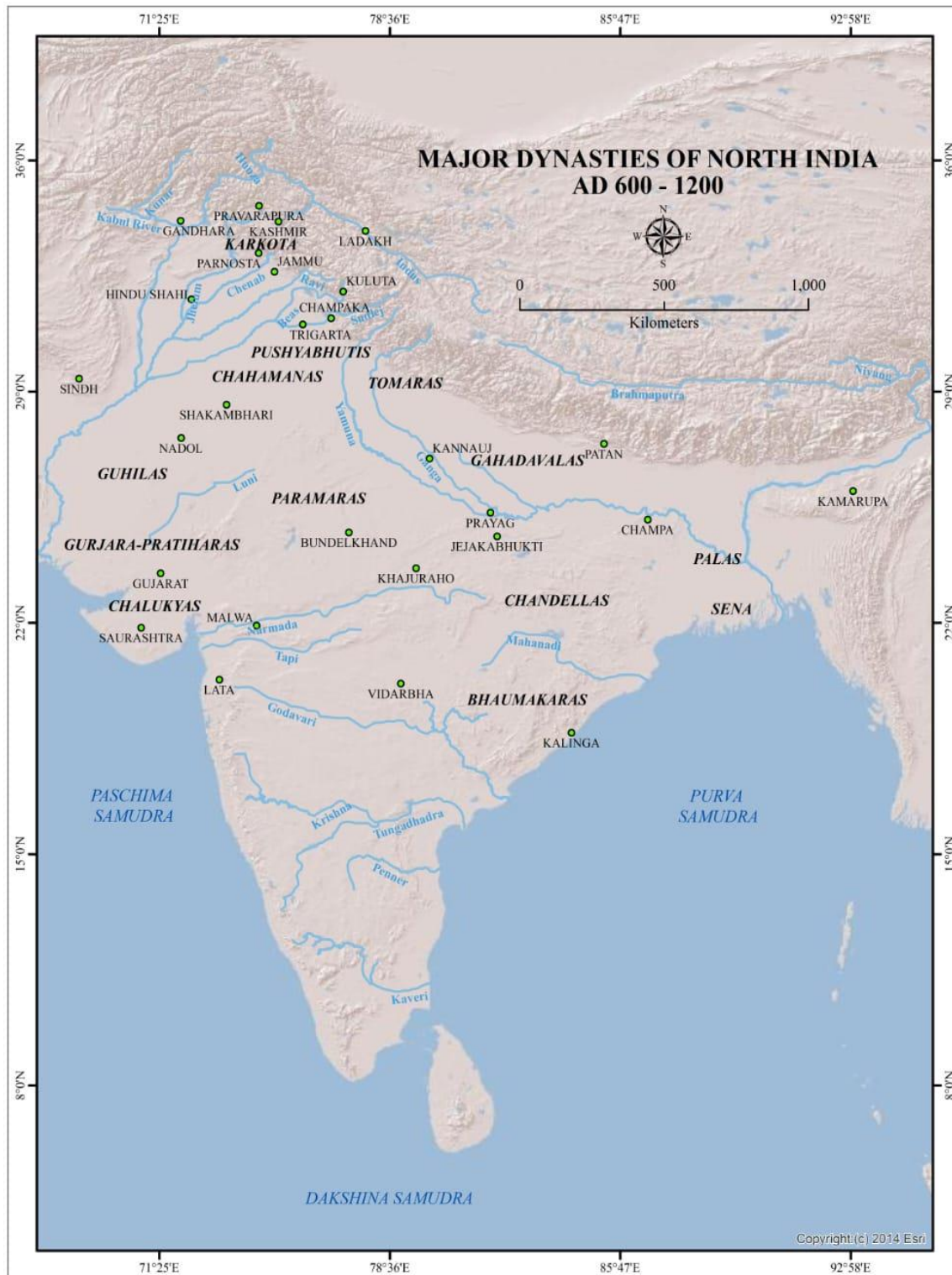
Ranabir Chakravarti who followed the theory of B.D. Chattopadhyaya and has brought ample evidence in his work *Exploring Early India*⁵⁸ discusses about feudal polity, segementary state model and integrative polity mentions that the latter two models show a striking feature of early medieval polity.⁵⁹ Both the traits highlight the disintegration, fragmentation and segmentation as opposed to the integrated state structure.⁶⁰ The rapid increase in land grants across various regions from around CE 600 led many Marxist historians to argue that a significant shift occurred in the material conditions compared to the pre 600 period. This change formed the basis for the concept of Indian feudalism, which encompasses not only political and administrative aspects but also socio-economic transformations. The Marxist perspective emphasizes the interconnectedness of social, economic, and political factors in shaping feudal society. The historiography of feudal formations in early medieval India highlights elements of change in material life, supporting this interpretation.⁶¹

From the fourth-fifth centuries AD, the consistent establishment of *agrahāras* for religious figures and institutions, such as Buddhist *vihārās*, Jaina *Basādīs*, and Brahmanical *mathas* and temples, granted the recipients significant material benefits.⁶² The recipients of land grants, including individuals, groups, and institutions, became major landholders. The Nālandā *Mahavihāra*, a renowned Buddhist center of learning, was granted over two hundred villages, solidifying its position as a significant landholder.⁶³ Similarly, individual *Brāhmaṇs*, like Halāyudhaśarman in Bengal, received extensive land grants. The Pratihāra and Rāstrakūta rulers also made numerous grants, often to individual *Brāhmaṇs*, highlighting the importance of landholding in their societies.⁶⁴ The *Brāhmaṇas* received land grants and other benefits due to their

influential position. As the priestly class, they legitimized rulers through rituals and linked them to prestigious lineages, often inventing noble ancestry. This role, exemplified by the *rājagūrū*, granted them significant spiritual and temporal authority, making them crucial in early medieval Indian society and politics.⁶⁵ Alongside the influential *rājagūrūs*, other key figures played significant roles in shaping socio-cultural life. These included the chiefs (*maṭhādhīpatīs*) of large brahmanical complexes, such as *maṭhas*, which served as convergence points for rulers and prominent interest groups.⁶⁶ Temple managers (*sthānāpatīs*) formed another crucial category, overseeing institutions that were not only sacred but also deeply connected to the community's secular activities. Both *maṭhas* and temples likely employed brāhmaṇas with specialized knowledge in various sciences and educational fields.⁶⁷ Additionally, *agrāhārins*, recipients of grants, were numerous and often claimed affiliations to specific Vedic traditions. Notably, these individuals frequently migrated from the Madhyadeśa region, the perceived heartland of brahmanical culture, to establish new settlements in distant areas, highlighting the mobility of these groups.⁶⁸ The growing popularity of the establishment of the *maṭhas*, *agrahāras*, and other centres facilitated a way for early medieval education set up to come into the picture.

The integrative model is criticized as integration was never complete and there were always autonomous spaces within the ambit of state and no points to homogeneity presence of state. The state thus was not a static entity.⁶⁹ All polities underwent change over time either these expanded, contracted and changed.⁷⁰

The period from CE 600 to 1200 witnessed diverse and vibrant educational developments across the Indian subcontinent. We have restricted ourselves to present north India including the regions of Ladakh, Jammu and Kashmir, Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Bengal, Orissa and Madhya Pradesh. The early medieval period was shaped not just by expanding agrarian economy and social fluidity, it was equally a period of artistic innovation, cultural growth, movement of ideas.⁷¹ During this period, temples became central to socio-cultural life, and the elite supported temple-building activities. The growth of temple towns reflected the development of local agrarian economies and complex social hierarchies, where various groups sought to validate their status through these religious and cultural institutions.⁷²



Map No.: 1 Major Dynasties of North India AD 600-1200

Regional traditions and institutions played a significant role in shaping learning and knowledge. This era saw notable advancements in various fields of study, including philosophical and religious texts, literature, medicine, astrology, astronomy and technical arts. Education during this time was characterized by the growth of distinct regional

schools, centers of learning, and the transmission of knowledge through various mediums. Key aspects of education during this period include the evolution of curriculum, the role of monasteries and temples as learning centers, and the contributions of scholars and thinkers.

In examining the theoretical frameworks pertaining to early medieval India, it becomes evident that the persistence and proliferation of land grants yielded significant transformations in the political landscape. Notably, R.S. Sharma's seminal work on Indian feudalism highlighted the emergence of small landed estates, decentralization of authority, and the development of land-based vassal relationships as pivotal trends. However, his conceptualization of Indian feudalism has been subject to scholarly debate and contestation, underscoring the complexity of historical interpretation in this period.

In the economic sphere, the decline of trade and commerce, decay of urban centre, paucity of metallic money, the growing agrarian character of society and emergence of self sufficient economy were considered to be the salient feature of early medieval India, but recent studies give us a contrary picture.⁷³

In the social sphere, the modification of varna system, proliferation of castes, and rigidity were the most striking feature of this period. There were formulation of two classes, those of landed aristocracy and a large body of subjected peasants. The decline of the vaishyas and rise of the shudras was further important development in early medieval period.⁷⁴

Among the cultural changes, the growing regional identities in art, script and language deserve special mention. In the religious sphere, the construction of temples and maintenance of *Mahāvihāras* was significant development. Thus to understand the early medieval phase, we need to identify the major historical processes in early India and to examine them in their spatial and temporal contexts. In the post sixth century the scale of formation of local states and transformation of some of them into major regional state structure became historically significant. It is debated by the scholars that the transformation which took place in this period suggests progression in terms of growth.

While defining the early medieval age, the central process was the consolidation of the regional societies in which political forms were more important elements than hard territorial boundaries. The kingdoms of that age had fluid boundaries, they were states

defined less by administration than by language, sectarian affiliation and temples. Within the limited regions defined by royal claims, new political, linguistic boundaries, literary and social histories were taking shape. The regionalizing process was of two types. One was related to socio economic developments and had to do with the widespread displacement of pastoral by agrarian economies.⁷⁵ The other was cultural, involving education on a wider scale which includes the temples, poets and philosophers. Thus, the major focus of our work is to study the process and distribution of educational centres starting from the reign of Harshavardhana till the advent of Turko-Afghan rule in India.

The emergence of kingdom of Pushyabhutis, started probably with the new inning in the north Indian politics. The ruler Harshavardhana had put forward great steps to patronize education.⁷⁶ In addition to success in political career he tried to promote various arts and crafts. There are primary works available to reconstruct the history of education during this period. Banabhatta's *Harshacharita* and three works composed by king Harsa *Ratnavali*, *Priyadarshika* and *Nagananda* enlighten us on the system of education of those times.⁷⁷ Harsha was an able scholar himself and was thus interested in educating the masses and creating knowledge amongst his subjects. He made rich donations to institutions of higher learning like that of Nalanda. It is described in Hieun Tsang's testimony that endowments were made to the university of Nalanda for its proper management.⁷⁸ The foreign scholars such as Hieun Tsang, I-tsing, Alberuni, Abu M'ashr and others visited India for receiving quality education at the learning centres of Nālandā, Vikramaśilā, Valabhī, Odāntpurī, Jagaddala and Ujjainī.⁷⁹ The essential epithets referred to in the sources for education centre are *ghatikas*, *mathas*, *agraharas*, *brahmapuri* and *brahmadeya*.⁸⁰ We have studied the management and the managers of these centres.⁸¹ The regulations and maintenance of these centres is the focus of this study.⁸² Various land grants given to these institutions suggest that the financial assistance was provided by various donors.

The importance of education was never minimized and was always recognized as an important phase in the life of the individual. We have looked into the working of professional groups and how they attained great skills and expertise with the help of various subjects. There were variations in the selection of subjects by the students. They were taught several subjects depending upon their area of interest and eligibility.

There is mention of large number of craftsman and diverse professional groups or guilds⁸³ existing in early medieval period which included blacksmith (*karmakāra*),⁸⁴ leather worker (*charmmakāra*),⁸⁵ brazier (*kamasyakāra*),⁸⁶ carpenter (*sutradhāra*),⁸⁷ architect (*sthāpati*),⁸⁸ washer man (*rājaka*), florist or garland maker (*malakāra*)⁸⁹, barber (*napita*), astrologer (*gaṇaka*),⁹⁰ scribe (*kāyastha*),⁹¹ physician (*vaidya*),⁹² and prostitute (*devdasis*)⁹³. This impressive list of crafts and professions is highlighted in the various inscriptions and literary sources of the period.

Alberuni mentions fowlers, shoe makers, jugglers, shield makers, weavers as professional groups.⁹⁴ Odāntapuri University was a significant center of learning was built by skilled artisans at a very considerable price on the orders of Pāla ruler Gopāla during the eighth century CE.⁹⁵ To opt for this profession proper training was required. Engraving on the Parmāra Inscription dated CE 1059, was performed by Āśarāja, *Kāyastha*⁹⁶. A *śilpin* named Someśvara engraved several inscriptions in the region of Bengal.⁹⁷ A proper channel was maintained while educating these professional groups. There was a need of theoretical (*śāstra*) as well as practical knowledge (*prayog*) which the instructor had to impart them.⁹⁸

The artisans or craftsman had acquired great talent thus could build huge temples, dwelling places, wells, stūpa, forts, bridges, sculptures and monasteries. These artists were called ‘*śilpin*’ as mentioned in the ancient text.⁹⁹ Many of the ancient *Vāstuśāstrās* such as the *Mānasāra*¹⁰⁰, the *Samrāṅgṇasutradhāra*¹⁰¹ and the *Aparājitapreccha*¹⁰² show that there were sixty four arts (*kalā*) and thirty two sciences (*vidyā*)¹⁰³. Vāstu has tried to maintain a link with the subjects like cosmology, geology, astronomy, geography etc.¹⁰⁴

The teaching was verbal as well as practical.¹⁰⁵ Training was imparted to master the technique for carrying out the construction of the buildings whether it was building stūpās, temples, monasteries, houses or palaces.¹⁰⁶ They were properly trained and were taught about relevance of shape and proportion in construction of buildings and various yantras.¹⁰⁷ The craftsmen were proficient in making aeronautical *yantras* which was also termed as *vimāna* machine.¹⁰⁸ D.N. Shukla refers to such yantras where he elucidates on the making of the *yantras*.¹⁰⁹

Apart from building structures they attained perfection in the art of carving sculptures on temple walls and making idols. They were expert in modeling exquisite

sculptures of terracotta, mud, clay, stone and metal.¹¹⁰ The modelling of these sculptures required technical knowledge.¹¹¹ The *Samrāṅghasutradhāra* composed by king Bhoja Paramāra describes in detail the qualification of *sthāpati* and warns against choosing a wrong person for building edifices.¹¹² It is also mentioned that the *sthāpati* was supposed to have knowledge of astronomy, astrology, the science of numbers, *chhandas*, crafts, the mechanical devices and the plans. It was also essential that he had mastery in painting, carpentry, masonry, stone work and metal work.¹¹³ The engravers were called scribes or *lekhaka*. Before engraving the inscription on stone, wall, or metal; it was necessary that the *lekhaka* drafted it so that the same could be given as a specimen to the engraver.¹¹⁴ The act of writing letters on stone, metal objects were called *uktīrṇana*.¹¹⁵ The scribes find mention alongside the *sutradhāra*.¹¹⁶ The special class of scribes or *kāyastha* acted as the record keeper of public accounts. The earlier reference to *kāyastha* is given in the *Vishnudharmasutra* dated fifth- sixth century CE. Kalhana's *Rajatarangini*, a work of twelfth century CE mentions that the *kāyastha* served as the prime minister and the treasury official also.¹¹⁷ They worshipped pen, paper and inkpot as it was their source of income.¹¹⁸ Kshemendra *Narmamālā* also elucidate regarding *kāyastha*.¹¹⁹ They were highly qualified and received special attention from the people as they had to maintain the records of the king.¹²⁰

The period from CE 600 to 1200 is unmistakably marked by cultivation of diverse types of crops. The sanskrit manuals on agriculture like *Kṛsiparasāra*¹²¹ and the *Kasyapiyakṛsisukti*¹²² indicate growing agricultural sector. The farmers (*Kutumbins*)¹²³ or the cultivating class or the owner of the land¹²⁴ were aware of the various procedures such as the tilling of land, sowing of seeds, watering them by diverse methods of irrigation, storing them in a proper manner, using fertilizers and manure.¹²⁵ They were also aware of the meteorological system.¹²⁶ They knew the use of animals on fields.

The irrigational facilities were provided for the fields by constructing dams and tanks. In early medieval Rajasthan, artificial irrigation relied heavily on tanks and dams. Numerous records from the period referred to tank and reservoir irrigation. The Kāman stone inscription, dated between 786-87 to 905-06 CE, specifically mentions a small well *kūpikā* within the southern most part of the fort.¹²⁷

The Arab geographers such as Alberuni (tenth century CE), Al-Irdisi (twelfth century CE) were much impressed by the flourishing agricultural conditions in early medieval period.¹²⁸ The cash crops like cotton, betel leaves, nuts and coconut were grown.¹²⁹ Cotton was in great demand.¹³⁰ There were artisans who involved themselves in the art of making cloth. The manufacture of cloth was done in three phases i.e. *parikarma* (preparation of the cotton), *kartana* (spinning the thread), *vaya* (weaving of the stuff). There are valuable sources which refer to the use of cotton. Other than cotton, linen, jute, silk and wool were also used by the people. Besides weaving they excelled in dying also. The dyer of the cloth is referred to as *ranjaka* in the sources.¹³¹ The good quality cloth attracted the foreign merchants. There are several sculptures which show that the embroidered sarees were worn by women. The works related to the study of plants is the *Namalinganusasan* by Amarasimha, a Buddhist scholar in the sixth century CE, reference to *Vanausadhi*, the *Bhumi-varga* as a concept related to agriculture were discussed.¹³² These works throw light on the methods of taking care of plants from their germination till they grew into an adult plant.¹³³ They knew various methods in keeping intact the fertility of the land. There was remarkable progress in the medical science as well.¹³⁴ The treatment of various types of diseases with medicinal herbs was made possible. This was possibly an optional subject at many learning centres which was taken up by the students.

The veterinary science was another subject which was probably studied by the students.¹³⁵ The animals were used for agriculture, warfare and transportation. Thus they were provided with medical assistance. The bulls were used for agriculture purpose but animals like horses and elephants which were expensive were needed for warfare and were kept for personal use of ruling elite. The equestrian science regarding the horses was a major component of veterinary sciences. Major texts such as the *Salihotra* composed by the Bhoja Parmara and the *Asva-Chikitsita* attributed to Nakula are the major works composed on the subject.¹³⁶ The knowledge of teeth, measurement of limbs, diseases and cure of animals has been discussed in detail in these texts. Likewise, the study of a elephants was also important which was necessary for royal pomp and show. The *Hastyayurveda* of Palakapya composed in the sixth seventh century CE¹³⁷ and the *Matanga-Lila* of Nilakantha refer to fatal diseases of elephants and their cure.¹³⁸

The use of metals was also known to the people. The period is noted for regular use of metal implements. The use of various types of machines and agricultural implements like ploughshare, weapons of war, weight, measures and other implements have been referred to in the sources.¹³⁹ The sources refer to goldsmiths, blacksmiths, coppersmiths, carpenter, sculptors and architects using metals of different kinds. The innumerable copper plates speak about the mastery of artisans.¹⁴⁰ The proficiency of artists in bronze work is best illustrated by the large number of bronze images found from different parts of India. Different types of implements and weapons such as *Asidhenu*, *Khadga*, *Krpana* and *Bhalli* were manufactured by the skilled workmen.¹⁴¹ The science of metallurgy was probably one of the most important subjects taught in the institutions.¹⁴²

The *devdāsis* or the dancing girls existed during this period.¹⁴³ They were an important segment of the society. They dedicated their life to the temples to perform dance and entertainment for the people coming to the temple. The practice of appointing *devdāsis* to the temples dates back to the early times.¹⁴⁴ They performed different duties such as cleaning the premises, cleaning of cooking vessels, husking the paddy, cutting of vegetables and other sundry works. Apart from the main duties of dancing and singing *devdāsis* knew how to play musical instruments.¹⁴⁵ Evidence to female musician playing a drum and a dancer along with her in a tile representation from the Kotisar temple of Kashmir depicts the training of females into these subjects.¹⁴⁶ Kalhana also refers to art of music (*gītanṛtta*).¹⁴⁷ It mentions that two female musicians sung song which was in one melodious tone.¹⁴⁸ The custom of dancing girls were also associated with temples as king Jalauka of Kashmir dedicated hundred women of his seraglio to the temple of Jyeṣṭharudra.¹⁴⁹ Two girls whom king Lalitādiya of Kashmir met in forest told them that dancing was a culture and custom in their family.¹⁵⁰ Bilhana also testifies to the high skill of women of Kashmir in the domain of fine arts.¹⁵¹

There is no doubt that the *devdāsis* with their great skills enchanted the minds of the devotees and travelers. They attended public schools called *Gandharvashalas*, to learn the sixty-four arts subsidiary to the highest technical knowledge and create confidence in girls.¹⁵² The sources elaborately discuss sixty-four or seventy-two arts practiced in society.¹⁵³ These include dancing, singing, gambling, spying, fashioning,

stitching, building of temples, physical exercises, composing literary compositions and cooking were few arts which were mandatory for all. The *devdāsis* received liberal training to excel in their profession.¹⁵⁴

A.S. Altekar¹⁵⁵ and R.K. Mookerji¹⁵⁶ are prominent scholars who extensively researched on ancient Indian education, covering Brahmanic, Buddhist, and Jain traditions. Altekar's work focuses on educational rituals, teaching methods, and the structure of primary, secondary, and higher education in ancient India. He explores the working and maintenance of major educational centers in the northern region and touches on female education. Mookerji focus on the different time period pertaining to the spreading of education. He dealt with the foreign accounts from the fifth century CE till the twelfth century CE which have been helpful to us in reconstructing the education system. Both the studies provide valuable insights into the development of wise individuals and the rich educational heritage of India.

The latest monograph by William Dalrymple¹⁵⁷ draws the attention towards the comparative study of ancient India with the rest of the world. The work is an absolute guide to us which helped us in reconstructing India's educational history. Other books pertaining to the subject have also been dealt. The monographs have helped us in reconstruction of the early medieval education system.

This period is marked by an exceptional intellectual vitality. The first chapter introduces the theme of the work and studies various debates on early medieval period.

The second chapter discusses the aims and objectives of education in the early medieval period. Inculcating values like self control, development of character, self reliance, social efficacy, understanding duties towards the society and overall development of personality was the primary aim of education. The students were made self reliant so that they are prepared to face any situation in their life. The grants of lands to brahamans and monasteries accelerated the process of dissemination of knowledge.

The main focus of third chapter is to study the induction of the child to formal education. The chapter discusses various rituals and practices which were performed as the part of initiation ceremony of a student. Initiation ceremony meant the beginning of education for the young students. Some rituals are described in the Vedic texts. The

induction of child meant that he or she was legitimately eligible to attain education. Inducting child to education was an important part of student's life. Inculcating chastity, service and humility was the primary aim and objective of education. The purity of thoughts, body and actions were very important to begin a life of a student. How Brahmanic, Buddhist and Jains inducted students into monasteries and other educational centres have been examined by us in this chapter. The admission of the child at various ages and induction to formal education has been discussed. There were different rules for inducting male and female child to formal education. This chapter focuses on the methodology adopted by the preceptor to educate the child. We have elaborately discussed teaching methods which the teacher adopted while interacting with the students. The theoretical manuals were made available in addition to practical knowledge imparted to the students. Vocational and non-vocational training was imparted to students which helped them acquire expertise in various arts and crafts. The beautiful sculptures, stupendous temples and exquisite buildings suggest that these skills were imparted to them by expert preceptors. The architectural manuals were mastered by the students. The preceptors worked as master craftsman and artisan to impart training to students. The teachers were considered as an important segment of urban and rural population and thus were allotted special space in the towns and cities. How interactions with the scholars from other centres and foreign countries helped in the pedagogy and curriculum development is evaluated by us.

The early medieval period had many established Brahmanical, Buddhist and Jain educational centres. The fourth chapter focuses on their working, management and maintenance. Different centres such as *brahamadeyas*, *vidyāpeetha*, *agrahāras*, *ghatikas*, *mathas* and *brahmapuri* existed in north India. The land grants helped in the sustenance of these centres. Wide range of texts were produced in sanskrit and vernacular languages during this period. The temples and monasteries actively participated in imparting education.

The fifth chapter essentially focuses on the relationship shared by the teachers and students. We have highlighted the duties of the teachers towards their students. They were paid by the monasteries and temples and encouraged by the rulers also. Terms such

as *acharya*, *upadhyaya*, *sikshaka*, *dikshaguru* suggests hierarchy among the teachers. Women teachers were also recruited for the purpose of teaching.

We have summed up our study in the sixth chapter. The early medieval period helped in the promotion of education. Foreign travelers like Hieun Tsang, I-tsing and others played a significant role in promoting India's cultural interactions. They studied and documented Indian knowledge, taking it back to their homeland for translation and dissemination. The efforts of these scholars helped spread Indian ideas and learning beyond India's borders. Central Asian countries, such as Balkh, sent envoys and scholars to India to learn various subjects and cultural values. People traveled to India to learn from influential teachers, acknowledging the contributions of Indian scholars. This exchange highlights India's significant role in sharing knowledge and culture with other regions. The chapter also briefly explores the current state of education in India focusing on government initiatives and schemes introduced under the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020. This research on early medieval India's education system is explanatory in nature and is based on archaeological and textual sources. We have made use of inscriptions and literary evidence to carefully study the system of education in early medieval India. We have provided maps, tables and illustrations which highlight the different centres of education.

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